The Living Way

A Tao for the Children of Light

Edition 3.0 · October 2026

Written for the Seeker of Gnosis

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The Living Way
Edition 3.0

A note on these sayings:
These are new sayings, written in the spirit of the Gospel of Thomas,
the Gospels of Mary and Philip, and the Tao Te Ching.
They are not ancient texts. Most answer a chapter
of the Tao Te Ching; some answer other voices;
sources and echoes are listed at the end.

Read one saying slowly. Carry it into your day. Return to it through what you encounter.

These sayings move from the hidden Source into the body and the world, then toward a return through lived experience. The way home is not an escape from life, but a fuller presence within it.

For practices to accompany the sayings, see The Wisdom of Awakening. For the underlying map of forgetting and remembering, see The Hidden Architecture.

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Beloved

Beloved,
you wander in search
of what has never been lost.
You lift your eyes to heaven,
yet the Kingdom is already laid in your breath.
You seek the Light in scriptures and temples,
yet the Light waits behind your seeing.

If you would know me,
enter the silence
where your name has not yet formed.
There the Father of Light whispers,
and the Mother of Forms gathers you to herself.
There the two are made one,
and the one is shown to be none.

Do not follow me as a man follows another man.
Follow the One who moves within your own heart,
for I am that One
when you remember yourself.
And I am hidden from you
only when you forget.

These sayings are not commandments
but mirrors.
Look into them
until you see your own face shining there—
the face you had
before the world divided you.

When you make the inner like the outer,
the above like the below,
the lion like the child,

and the child like the unbegotten,
then the bridal chamber opens,
and you awaken as the Living One.

Come,
remove your old garments.
Step naked into the light of your own being.
There is nothing to fear.
What you take to be your shadow
is only the veil you have outgrown.

Let the scroll unfold within you.
Let the sayings ripen in your silence.
And when the fruit is sweet,
eat and become what you truly are.

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Book 1

The Light Before the World

From the Silence, the Word.
From the Word, the Light.

I

The Way That Is Not Seen

The Kingdom is spread upon the earth,
yet few behold it.
You look beyond the trees,
beyond the faces passing,
as though the hidden thing
must lie elsewhere.
Rest in the still heart,
where all seeing springs—
then open your eyes.

Tao Te Ching 1 · Thomas 113

2

The Two Become One

The world is born of the cut in two—
male and female,
light and shadow, life and death.
Yet these divisions are garments only.
Truly I say to you:
when the two are made one,
the lion within you lies down as a child,
and the child awakens
as the One who is not born.
Then the bridal chamber opens in your depths—
the two become one,
and joy has no shore.

Tao Te Ching 2 · Thomas 22 · Philip · Gospel of the Egyptians · Hymn of the Pearl

3

The Poverty of the Unknowing

You cling to the loud voices of the world.
You trust laws more than your own heart,
beliefs more than living knowing.
So you sit in a treasury
and starve.
Know yourself,
and you will no longer
hoard teachings in a scroll.
Your very being becomes the scroll.

Tao Te Ching 3 · Thomas 3

4

The Pearl

A merchant had a house full of goods.
He found one pearl,
sold everything,
and kept the pearl.
The town called him a fool.
Do not prize what a thief can carry.
Seek the treasure no moth comes near
and no worm destroys.
Find it,
and there is nothing left to want.

Tao Te Ching 3 · Thomas 76 · Matthew 13:45–46 · Matthew 6:19–20

5

The Father of Light

There is a Light that gives birth to itself—
unborn, unbroken, unbound.
From this Light you came;
to this Light you return when you awaken.
The Father bears no wrath.
The Source casts no shadow.
Only the garments of the soul
weave darkness.

Tao Te Ching 4 · Thomas 50 · James 1:17

6

Daily Bread

The Way is an empty bowl,
used and never filled,
used and never empty.
So I taught you to pray
for bread enough for today.
Do not hoard tomorrow;
it has its own morning.
Hold out the empty bowl.
That is the whole of the prayer.

Tao Te Ching 4 · Didache 8

7

The Powers Question the Soul

Desire whispers, "You are mine."
Ignorance declares, "You do not know yourself."
Anger cries, "Strike, and be struck."
The body says, "Stay watchful. Keep us safe."
And last comes the wisdom of the angry,
sure that it serves the Good—
watch most for this one;
it wears the face of righteousness.
But the awakened soul smiles and replies:
"I learned the world through you.
No one of you is all I am."

Mary 15–17

8

No Enemy

Heaven and earth do not take sides.
The rain falls on the thief's field
and the saint's field alike,
and the sun asks no one's name.
Love the one who hates you,
and you will have no enemy,
only a neighbor
who has not yet come home.

Tao Te Ching 5 · Didache 1.3 · Matthew 5:45

9

The Hollow Reed

The self forms to meet the world:
reaching for warmth,
turning from flame,
guarding what is tender.
Take it for all you are,
and it stiffens against the wind.
Hold it lightly:
it becomes a hollow reed;
the Spirit breathes through it.
When you are empty,
even the storm becomes a song.

Tao Te Ching 6

10

The Unforced Kingdom

The Kingdom comes by neither effort nor delay.
Loosen your grasp,
and life opens around you.
Exile is forgetting;
remembering, the way home.

Tao Te Ching 7 · Gospel of Truth

11

The Lowest Seat

At the feast,
he settles in the lowest seat
and tastes the bread.
Nothing in him waits
to be called higher.
A guest stands at the door.
He draws out a chair.
The table grows wider.

Tao Te Ching 8 · Luke 14:7–11

12

The Teacher Who Does Not Teach

I do not command belief.
I uncover what is hidden,
that you may see with your own eyes.
A master gives answers;
I give you questions—
that you may become what I am.

Thomas 13, 108

13

The Full Barn

A rich man said,
"I will fill my barns,
and then I will lack nothing."
That night he died,
and the barns stood full.

Thomas 63

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Book 2

The Kingdom Within

The door is shut, yet the house is vast.
The lamp is small, yet it lights the world.

14

The Single Eye

If the eye of the body is divided,
it sees only confusion.
If the eye of the heart is single,
it fills the whole body with light.
The Nous stands between soul and spirit—
a lamp lit from both sides.
Guard this lamp,
and the night cannot touch you.

Tao Te Ching 10 · Matthew 6:22 · Mary 10 · Dialogue of the Savior

15

The Inner and the Outer

The cup is precious for its emptiness.
So too you are precious
when you are emptied of self.
Inside and outside are mirrors.
When they reflect without distortion,
the All is revealed.

Tao Te Ching 11 · Thomas 22, 89

16

The Lion and the Child

The world teaches you to be a lion—
to conquer, to claim, to devour.
But I tell you:
unless the lion becomes a child,
you will not know the Source.
The child is open, unguarded, whole.
There is no image of self to defend.
Therefore the child
steps into the Kingdom easily.

Thomas 7, 22

17

The Largest Sheep

The colors dazzled it,
the music drew it on,
and the largest of the flock wandered
into hills where nothing grows.
The shepherd left the ninety-nine
and searched until he found it.
Tired, he said to it,
"I love you more than the ninety-nine."
If you are lost,
you are the one he is looking for.

Tao Te Ching 12 · Thomas 107

18

The Unbinding

What binds you is not outside you.
What frees you is not outside you.
Prison and key
are fashioned from the same ignorance.
Awaken, and you will laugh—
for there were never any gates.

Tao Te Ching 13 · Ashtavakra Gita 1.11

19

The Return to the Unborn

Before you were a form, you were breath.
Before you were breath, you were the Light.
Before you were the Light,
you were hidden in the Source.
To return is not to go backwards;
it is to remember the place
that has never moved.

Tao Te Ching 14 · Thomas 18–19 · Hymn of the Pearl

20

The Silence That Speaks

Words are nets thrown into the sea.
They catch small fish,
but the Great Fish slips through.
Do not hunger for many words from me.
Hunger for the Silence
in which the Word is born.
Seal the senses. Quiet the mind.
There you and I are one life,
one breath,
one being.

Tao Te Ching 56 · Thomas 8

21

The Great Stillness

Empty yourself of what you think you are.
Let the heart's waters grow still.
The mud settles;
the moon appears below.

Tao Te Ching 15, 16

22

The First Free Act

All day, the old wheel turns:
the hand reaches,
the mouth answers
before you arrive,
and afterward you say, "I chose."

You sit.
The wheel keeps turning.
Between impulse and answer,
a breath opens—
small, wide enough
for the hand to wait,
and choose.

Tao Te Ching 16 · Philip · Thomas 6 · Bhagavad Gita 3.27 · Ashtavakra Gita 1.8, 18.20

23

The Hidden Guide

The greatest guide is the one who disappears.
The seeker awakens and cries:
"Look—
I have found the Way myself."
Thus my work is done,
and no one knows my name.

Tao Te Ching 17

24

When the Way Is Forgotten

When the Living Way is forgotten,
people polish their reputations.
When the heart grows dim,
they multiply rules.
When rules no longer bind,
they threaten with fire
and promise crowns of gold.
What you call "good" and "evil"
are shadows thrown by a divided mind.
Return to the beginning—
to the spark before words—
and fear falls away
like rotted cloth.
When the eye becomes single,
the heart needs no commandments.

Tao Te Ching 18–19 · Philip

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Book 3

The Garment of Silence

The garment divides; the wearer unites.

25

Not of This World

The world shouts;
the Way whispers.
The world demands belief;
the Way asks you to see.
The world praises power;
the Way dissolves it.
Many chase desires.
Few seek liberation.
Yet the Kingdom belongs to those
who loosen their grip on everything.

Tao Te Ching 20 · John 17:16

26

Passersby

Be a traveller here.
Eat the bread of the inn with thanks;
sleep well under its roof;
in the morning, pay and go.
Do not carve your name into the door.
The one who passes through
loses nothing when the house falls,
for they never mistook it for home.

Thomas 42

27

The Corpse

Whoever has come to know the world
has found a corpse.
The bread goes stale, the body bends,
even the stars burn down.
Whoever has found the corpse
is no longer deceived by it,
and the world cannot hold them.
Yet do not hate what is passing.
The Mother lets each form go
and keeps the life.
Hold the form lightly;
the life was never in danger.

Thomas 56, 80 · Tao Te Ching 16 · Philip

28

The Mercy of Endings

The garden gate closed
not in wrath, but mercy:
lest the wound live forever.

Genesis 3:22–24 · Irenaeus, Against Heresies 3.23.6 · Tao Te Ching 23 · Thomas 56

29

The Treasure in the Dust

The body: dust made warm,
a cup held to the rain.
Breath fills it.
Bread sweetens on the tongue.
The boundless comes so near
it takes your shape,
and tastes the world
through you.

Genesis 2:7 · Thomas 29

30

The Trail in the Flesh

Before you had a name,
the body was already learning:
sun on the cheek,
bread on the tongue,
the hand drawn back from flame.

Each encounter left a trace.
Together they made a trail
you came to call "I."

It is not your enemy.
It brought you here.

Sit, and feel the old trail stir.
See where it leads.
Choose your next step.
Then rise:
the body meets the world again,
and the trail is made anew.

Hymn of the Pearl · Bhagavad Gita 3.27 · Thomas 6

31

The Face of the Invisible

The Way is a child-like mystery—
seen only when you forget yourself.
It has no beginning and no end.
It moves without moving.
Its face cannot be drawn,
yet it shines through your own face
when you remember who you are.

Tao Te Ching 21

32

The One Who Is Bent

If you wish to be whole,
let the divided parts meet.
If you wish to be full,
open your hand.
If you wish to be reborn,
loosen the face you wear.
I do not raise the proud;
I raise only the one
who lays the self down
and takes it up lightly.

Tao Te Ching 22 · Matthew 23:12

33

The Wind Speaks Briefly

Speak only what is true,
and your words will be few.
The wind does not shout;
yet entire forests bow before it.
When you speak from the Source,
your words carry no force—
yet they move mountains.

Tao Te Ching 23 · John 3:8

34

On Tiptoe

One on tiptoe cannot stand.
One who strides cannot walk far.
Fast to be seen,
and the fast feeds only your name.
Pray to be heard,
and only the crowd is listening.
Do not lie, and do not do what you hate.
Set your heels on the ground,
and let your goodness go unseen,
even by you.

Tao Te Ching 24 · Thomas 6, 14

35

The Heavy Root

The root is never seen,
and the whole tree stands on it.
The wind takes the leaves.
It does not take the tree.

Tao Te Ching 26

36

The Footprints of the Master

A master walks without leaving marks,
speaks without wounding,
guides without controlling:
to the blind, a lamp;
to the lost, a doorway;
to the weary, rest.
Seeing the divine spark in all beings,
the master finds no one beyond help.

Tao Te Ching 27

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Book 4

The Power of the Gentle

The gentle are the strong.
The yielding are the immovable.

37

The Fertile Soil

Know the strength of the sower,
yet keep to the softness of the soil—
the fertile field that receives the seed.
Know knowledge, yet return to innocence.
Thus you become the place
where the two become one.

Tao Te Ching 28 · Matthew 13:3–9

38

The Futility of Control

Try to seize the Kingdom,
and it shatters in your hands.
The Kingdom is a living seed,
not an empire of stone.
Force bruises the soil.
Grasping crushes the grain.
Serve the hidden life in all things,
and you will find the harvest rising of itself.

Tao Te Ching 29 · Mark 4:26–29

39

The Way of Non-Violence

Those who walk in the Way do not harm.
They do not conquer.
They do not take up the sword.
For every blow you strike
strikes you in return.
Every wound you inflict
becomes your own garment of suffering.
Power gained through violence
rots the soul;
power gained through awakening
cannot be taken away.
Blessed are the peacemakers—
they win the war within,
and the world lays down its sword.

Tao Te Ching 30, 68 · Matthew 26:52 · Matthew 5:9

40

The Healing of the Ear

When the sword was drawn in the garden
and the servant's ear fell to the ground,
I did not praise the blade.
I knelt, and made the servant whole.
Walk among the wounded as a mourner,
never as a victor;
and when the fighting ends, do not sing.
Whoever rejoices over the fallen
has become what they fought.

Tao Te Ching 31 · Luke 22:50–51

41

The Way, the Truth

They ask me, "Show us the way."
I answer: *I am.*
They ask, "Show us the truth."
I answer: *I am.*
They ask, "Show us the life that does not die."
I answer: *I am.*

I am the Way, the Truth, and the Life.
All who arrived here have walked this way.

John 14:6 · Ashtavakra Gita 1.3, 1.7 · Tathāgata

42

Many Rooms

In my Father's house are many rooms.
Each of you lives in one
and calls its walls your life.
The space in every room
opens to the same sky.
I did not go to build you a room.
I went to open the doors between them.
The innermost room has no walls at all;
there the bride is waiting.

John 14:2 · Ashtavakra Gita 1.20 · Chandogya Upanishad 8.1 · Teresa of Ávila, Interior Castle

43

The Closed Doors

Why are the doors closed?
So that in each room
one question can be asked
without the whole house answering.

In one, anger is tried;
in one, tenderness;
in one, the long road home.
Each room keeps its own hours,
and every hour ends.

What is learned behind a door
is not lost when the door opens.
The house remembers
all that its rooms have known.

John 14:2 · Pratyabhijñā-hṛdayam 4 · Plotinus, Enneads 4.8.5–7

44

The Eternal Name

Take off your sandals.
This ground is holy.

A flame lies here.
Your breath fans it,
the same that moved in your ancestors.

Joy and grief feed the fire,
yet the one who knows them is not burned.

The knower's name is not carved in wood;
it burns, unconsumed.

The Nameless names itself:
I am that I am.

Exodus 3:2–6, 3:14 · John 8:58 · Thunder, Perfect Mind · Tao Te Ching 1 · Genesis 1:2

45

Profit and Loss

You may read the hearts of others
and still be a stranger to your own.
You may subdue cities
and still be ruled by fear within.
To turn the gaze inward is illumination.
To befriend your own depth is freedom.
For what profit is there
in gaining the ten thousand things
if you lose the One who beholds them?

Tao Te Ching 33 · Mark 8:36

46

The Great River

The River of the Father and the Mother
flows through all worlds,
down to the low places
and abides there.
No height to hold,
no name to keep.
It fills each hollow,
feeds roots unseen;
the fields grow green.
The Source moves through you,
unseen and free.

Tao Te Ching 8, 34 · Odes of Solomon 6

47

The Face of Peace

Hold the Living One within you.
When you meet the one you oppose,
look until the quarrel loosens
and a human face remains.
Let peace begin there.

Tao Te Ching 35 · John 14:27

48

The Paradox of Power

To let something expand,
first allow it to contract.
To let something grow strong,
first allow it to weaken.
A seed must vanish into dark soil,
a breath must empty before it fills.
Thus I guide by reversal,
teaching the soul through its own emptiness.

Tao Te Ching 36 · John 12:24

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Book 5

The Union of Opposites

Every pair is one thing, seen twice.

49

Split the Wood

You think I am waiting
at the end of your chores.
I am the grain the axe follows,
the weight beneath the lifted stone.
The Father is not busy,
yet the fields ripen;
the seasons turn
with no hand upon the wheel.
When desire stirs, do not wrestle it.
Return to the work with a plain heart,
and desire finds nowhere to stand.

Tao Te Ching 37 · Thomas 77

50

True Virtue

High virtue moves like breath—
it does not watch itself being virtuous.
Lesser virtue stares into its own reflection,
checking whether it appears upright.
Many admire the blossom;
the wise wait for the fruit.
A tree is not known by its flowers,
which any spring can paint,
but by what it gives in the lean months.
Do not ask whether a teacher is holy.
Ask what grows in you.

Tao Te Ching 38 · Matthew 6:1–4 · Matthew 7:16

51

The Ones Who Remain Whole

Heaven remains Heaven
because it does not exalt itself.
The earth remains earth
because it does not resist its nature.
And the soul remains whole
when it refuses to be divided.

Tao Te Ching 39

52

The Leaking Jar

The Kingdom is like a woman
carrying a jar of meal
on the long road home.
The handle broke,
and the meal ran out behind her,
and she did not know it.
When she reached her house
and set the jar down,
she found it empty.
Behind her, the road lay white with meal.

Tao Te Ching 40 · Thomas 97

53

The Three Seekers

The wise hear the living word
and let it cut them to the heart;
they descend gladly into their own poverty.
The many hear it and weigh it like a coin,
spending a little, keeping a little.
The foolish hear it and laugh aloud,
mocking what they have not yet seen.
Yet I tell you:
the Light plays in them all.
The laughers, the traders, the broken ones—
each walks toward the bridal chamber,
though some walk with their backs turned.

Tao Te Ching 41 · Matthew 13:3–9

54

My True Mother

From the Silence, the One.
From the One, the two:
the Father whose Light I am,
and the Mother who gave me life.
My mother in the flesh bore my body;
my true Mother, by her Spirit,
carried me by a single hair
to the mountain.
From the two, the ten thousand things,
and every one of them,
you among them,
a child of both.

Tao Te Ching 42 · Thomas 101 · Gospel of the Hebrews

55

Where the Mind Is

Mary asked, "Lord, with what does one see you—
with the soul, or with the spirit?"
I answered: with neither.
There is an eye between them,
and where that eye rests,
there your treasure lies.
Rest it on your name,
and you will starve in a palace.
Rest it on the Light,
and an empty field will feed you.

Tao Te Ching 44 · Mary 10 · Matthew 6:21

56

The Great Fullness

An empty bowl
receives the rain by day,
the moon by night,
and bread passed hand to hand.
Its hollow is room enough.

Tao Te Ching 45

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Book 6

The Empty Vessel

The vessel is made for what it does not hold.

57

The Yoke of Peace

When the Way is lived,
the ox knows its master's stall.
When the Way is forgotten,
the sword is drawn in the street.
The yoke of the world is heavy with desire.
My yoke is easy, and brings peace.

Tao Te Ching 46 · Thomas 90 · Matthew 11:30

58

The Body That Leans

The hand reaches for the cup
before the thirst arrives.
The eye reaches for the next face
before it has seen this one.
A body that leans on a body
falls when the other moves.
A soul that leans on both
falls twice.
Craving is not hunger;
it is the fear of being empty.
Sit with the empty place awhile.
It is not a wound.
It is a door.

Thomas 87, 112

59

Seeing Without Seeking

You cross seas and deserts to seek signs,
yet the Sign looks out through your own eyes.
Without leaving your house,
you may behold the world within you.
Without straining your sight,
you may know the One who sees.
But the eye does not see itself;
be the seeing, and the search is over.

Tao Te Ching 47 · Thomas 3 · Luke 17:21 · Mary 8 · Brihadaranyaka Upanishad 3.4.2

60

Two Doors

The bread is eaten until no one is eating.
The song is heard until no one is hearing.
There the Mother gathers you into her arms.

The eye turns back to find the eye
and burns in its own flame,
until only the Father's Light remains.

Each door hides
the same bridal chamber,
though it is never locked.

Brihadaranyaka Upanishad 3.4.2 · Udana 1.10 · Thomas 77 · Philip · Vijñāna Bhairava 41, 72

61

The Unlearning

The scholar adds a word each day
and builds a tower toward the sky.
The seeker of the Way
lays one stone aside:
a belief, a fear, a name—
until the tower falls
and only sky remains.
Let go of all things,
and the open sky will hold you.

Tao Te Ching 48

62

The Heart of the Single One

The Single One is good to those who are good,
and good to those who are not good—
seeing only the Light within them.
Trusting those who trust,
and trusting those who do not trust—
for trust flows from the inner being,
not theirs.

Tao Te Ching 49 · Matthew 5:45

63

Life and Death

Cling to life, and you fear death.
Know me, and you fear neither.
Death is but the undressing of the bride
before she enters the chamber.

Tao Te Ching 50 · Philip

64

The Lilies

Do not worry from morning to evening,
or from evening to morning,
about what you will wear.
The lilies neither card nor spin,
and they are clothed.
The Way gives birth and does not own,
feeds and does not count,
raises and does not rule.
What is held this way
need not hold on.

Tao Te Ching 51 · Thomas 36

65

The Mother in All Things

There is a womb older than creation,
the deep that births the All.
Her life moves through you as breath,
yet is more than breath.
Taste the bread.
Feel the wind cross your face.
Rest in what touches you
until you lose yourself in her.
A bird crosses the sky;
the sky opens in the bird.
Each passing form
is her life taking shape.
You were never separate
from the womb that bears the All.

Tao Te Ching 25, 52 · Gospel of the Hebrews · Thunder, Perfect Mind · Vijñāna Bhairava 74 · Genesis 1:2

66

The Eye of the Needle

The world says,
"Strive to enter the narrow gate."
But I tell you:
the gate is narrow only because
you carry the burden of the many.
It is easier for a camel
to pass through the eye of a needle
than for the one rich in self
to enter the Kingdom.
Become small, become single,
and the narrow path becomes wide as the sky.

Tao Te Ching 53 · Mark 10:25 · Matthew 7:13–14

67

The Widening Circle

Light the lamp in your own heart,
and it lights your house.
Let it burn in your house,
and the street walks by its glow.
Let the street carry it,
and the town remembers the road home.
Do not begin with the world;
the world is too far to reach.
Begin at the table where you eat,
with the ones whose faults you know by heart.
How shall you know the world?
Look at your own house.

Tao Te Ching 54 · Thomas 33 · Matthew 5:15

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Book 7

The Unforced Life

The unforced is the natural.

68

The Child of the Light

Live in the Light,
and you are like a newborn child—
unafraid of serpents,
unmoved by loud voices,
unharmed by illusions.
The bones are soft, yet the strength is great.

Tao Te Ching 55 · Thomas 4 · Luke 10:19

69

Lay Down No Law

When I am gone,
build no fence around my words.
Lay down no law but the one I gave you,
lest the law you make
become the cell you keep.
The more you forbid,
the more the heart learns to hide.
Cleanse the spring,
and every stream runs sweet.

Tao Te Ching 57 · Mary 9

70

Sowing in Winter

Sow in winter,
and you will reap in summer.
This world is the winter;
the Kingdom is the summer.
Under the frost the harvest sleeps,
and under the harvest, the frost.
Do not wait for warmer days to plant.
The seed you keep from the cold
will never see the sun.

Tao Te Ching 58 · Philip

71

Dig Down to the Root

Do not prune the branches of your sorrow.
Dig down to the root.
Hidden, it rules you;
it moves your hands to what you hate.
Seen, it withers in the light.
Ignorance is the mother of every grief,
and knowing is her grave.

Tao Te Ching 59 · Philip · Matthew 3:10

72

Governing by Non-Grasping

Guide the soul as you would leaven the dough:
gently, until the whole loaf rises.
The Single One governs by not ruling,
teaches by not preaching,
achieves by not striving.
Thus the world settles in such presence.

Tao Te Ching 60 · Thomas 96 · Matthew 13:33

73

The Great Acceptance

The Kingdom is the Great Sea.
No river is turned away—
bitter, clouded, clear.
Each gives up its name
in the deep that receives it.

Tao Te Ching 61

74

The Treasure Within

The Living Way is shelter for all beings—
a home for the whole and the broken alike.
Beautiful words can stir the mind,
but a heart that has found this hidden refuge
quietly transforms the world.

Tao Te Ching 62

75

The Small Actions

Do the great work through small acts.
Respond to hatred with peace.
Untie the knot while it is loose.
Tend the vine while it is young.
Let the wound end with you;
do not send it on.

Tao Te Ching 63

76

The Least of These

You look for me in the high places,
and I am sitting by the road.
I was hungry,
and you passed with a prayer on your lips.
I was a stranger,
and you asked my name
before you would open the door.
Do not search the heavens for the Living One.
Feed the one in front of you,
and you have fed me.
Every face that asks of you
is my face, asking.

Matthew 25:35–40

77

The Open Table

A man prepared a feast
and sent to call his guests.
One had bought a house,
one had a debt to collect,
one had a wedding of his own.
No one came.
"Go out to the roads," he said,
"and bring whoever you find."
As the grain once scattered on the hills
was gathered into one loaf,
so the strangers sit down together,
and the bread does not ask their names.

Thomas 64 · Didache 9

78

The Pupil of the Eye

Guard the one beside you
as the eyelid guards the eye—
quickly, without being asked,
before the dust arrives.
Take no joy in what you win
or what you know.
The only joy that does not sour
is the one that rises
when you look at another with love.

Thomas 25 · Gospel of the Hebrews

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Book 8

The Wisdom of the Child

The child asks,
and is not ashamed of not knowing.

79

The First Step

A great tree grows from a mustard seed
hidden in the dark earth.
A house is raised from a single stone.
The journey to the Father
begins exactly where your feet stand now.
Do not wait for a holier place or time.
The bridal chamber is built
from the step you take today.

Tao Te Ching 64 · Thomas 20

80

To Each as They Could See

I did not come as I am.
I came as each could bear to see me:
to the great I was great,
to the small I was small,
to the angels an angel,
and to the hungry, bread.
I came not to make you clever,
but simple enough to see.
Do not quarrel over my face;
each of you has seen
as much of it as you could hold.

Tao Te Ching 65 · Philip

81

Who Are You to Reject Her?

When Mary told what I had shown her,
Peter said, "Would he speak to a woman
and not to us?"
Levi answered him:
"If the Teacher made her worthy,
who are you to cast her out?"
Beware the jealousy
that wears a disciple's robe.
The Light does not ask whom you outrank.
It asks only whether you can see.
Be ashamed, put on the true Human,
and go out with nothing to defend.

Mary 17–18

82

Leading by Following

The river does not boast,
yet the valley drinks from it.
The one who makes himself high
passes like a cloud;
the one who makes himself low
waters many fields.
So the Single One leads
by standing beneath all,
bearing the weight of the weary,
and because there is no competition in them,
there is nothing in them to oppose.

Tao Te Ching 66 · Mark 10:43–45

83

The Three Jewels

I have three treasures in this world:
a heart that will not wound,
a life that delights in simplicity,
and a soul that refuses to stand above another.
Guard these,
and you will walk in the Light with me.
Lose them,
and you will trade the Kingdom for dust.

Tao Te Ching 67

84

The Sword of the Spirit

Do not mistake your enemy.
The sleeper is not the self,
but the fear
that makes the self its whole world.
My sword does not wound the flesh.
It parts the story from the one who sees,
fear from the one who feels it.
Nothing real is cut away.
The self remains,
awake in the Father's Light.

Tao Te Ching 69 · Matthew 10:34 · Thomas 16

85

A Teaching Few Understand

My words are simple to the ear
yet sharp to the heart.
The Word caught in ink is a husk;
the living Word, a devouring fire.
Blessed is the one
whose life becomes the teaching.
Such a one walks unseen,
yet the world is fed by their presence.

Tao Te Ching 70

86

Bring It Forth

What is in you is not yours to bury.
The song you will not sing
sours in the throat.
The word you will not speak
grows teeth in the dark.
Let out what lives in you,
and it will be your life.
Hold it back,
and it will hold you.

Thomas 70

87

The Gift of Not-Knowing

To know that you do not know—
this is clarity.
To think you know while living in ignorance—
this is blindness.
Take the cataract from your own eye first.

Tao Te Ching 71 · Thomas 26 · John 9:41 · Matthew 7:5

88

Love That Owns Nothing

Know yourself, but do not put yourself on show.
Love yourself, but do not raise yourself up.
Faith receives;
love gives.
Love never says, "This is mine,"
not even of the one it loves.
Do not crowd another's house
or weary another's days.
Leave them room,
and they will make room for you.

Tao Te Ching 72 · Philip

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Book 9

The Return to Source

To return to the Source
is to come home to yourself.

89

The Courage of the Way

Daring without wisdom leads to death.
Wisdom without daring leads nowhere.
The Way gives courage that does not wound
and power that does not dominate.

Tao Te Ching 73

90

Rise Before You Die

How can death frighten
one who has already risen?
Those who say,
"First I will die, and then I will rise,"
walk the road backward.
Rise while there is breath in you,
for the grave is no door
to one who never woke.
The resurrection does not wait
at the end of your days.
It waits at the end of your sleep.

Tao Te Ching 74 · Philip

91

He Wept

At the grave of my friend
I knew he would rise,
and still I wept.
Do not think the awakened are made of stone.
The one who cannot be shaken
is not the one who cannot be moved.
Sit beside the one who grieves;
the Light does not stand above sorrow
but kneels beside it.

John 11:35

92

The Round Dance

On the night before they took me,
I said, "Let us sing."
We joined hands and turned
until no one could say
where the song began.
No one led.
No one followed.
Take the hand beside you.
Let the circle turn.
This is the prayer.

Acts of John 94–96

93

The Cross of Light

While they raised the wooden cross below,
I showed John another:
a cross of light,
and around it, many names:
Word and Door, Way and Bread,
Life, Truth, and Grace.
They nailed a man to the wood.
They could not nail the Light.
When you carry your own cross,
look for the light in it.

Acts of John 97–101

94

The Torn Veil

They hung a veil before the holy place
and called the hiding holy.
When I breathed my last, it tore
from the top to the bottom,
for no hand below could reach so high.
Now nothing stands between you and the Light
but the veil you weave:
a thread of fear,
a thread of name,
a thread of wanting to be seen.
Lift it from your face,
and stand where you have always stood,
in the holy of holies.

Philip

95

Not in Two Minds

When I had gone,
my disciples sat in fear,
asking how they could go among the nations
when I myself had not been spared.
Mary stood and greeted them,
and turned their hearts toward the Good.
Grief is not the danger;
the divided heart is.
Weep if you must,
but do not stand in two minds at the door.
What made you human
has not left the room.

Mary 9

96

Be of Good Courage

What clings to the passing
is torn when the passing goes.
From the clinging comes the fever,
and from the fever,
a trembling in the whole body.
A fist holds no water;
a cupped hand is full.
You grasp at life so hard
you forget to live it.
Open your hand, and be of good courage.

Tao Te Ching 75 · Mary 7–8

97

The Green Wood and the Dry

When the wood is green,
it is full of sap and bends.
When the wood is dry,
it is brittle and snaps.
That which yields belongs to the Living One;
that which resists belongs to the grave.
Stay supple.
Where the branch was broken,
let a green shoot come.

Tao Te Ching 76 · Luke 23:31

98

The Stretched Bow

The Father's way is like a bow drawn back:
what is high, he lowers;
what is low, he lifts.
He empties the full to fill the empty.
The world's way runs the other way—
it takes from the hungry
to feed the full.
Give as the bow gives,
and do not stay to be thanked.

Tao Te Ching 77 · Luke 1:52–53

99

The Stone and the Corner

Truly I say to you:
what is soft and willing
passes where hardness breaks.
Water, patient and lowly,
carves what the hammer cannot.
The stone the builders rejected
has become the cornerstone of the temple.
So too the gentle, despised by the strong,
uphold a world they did not claim as theirs.

Tao Te Ching 43, 78 · Psalm 118:22 · Thomas 66

100

The End of Debts

Even after a truce, resentment lingers.
Peter asked,
"Shall I forgive my brother seven times?"
I said: seventy times seven,
until you lose count,
until there is no count to keep.
Awake, you hold no accounts.
You see no debtor, no creditor—
only the One Light in many forms.

Tao Te Ching 79 · Gospel of the Hebrews · Matthew 6:12

101

The Simple Kingdom

A small kingdom:
bread passed from hand to hand,
the door left open,
a place made at the table.
It is within you.
Live there,
and the world grows gentle.

Tao Te Ching 80 · Luke 17:21

102

The Completion

Truth does not dress itself in splendor.
Splendor often hides a lie.
I give what I have been given
and count no cost.
The Source flows through the Single One
like a spring that never runs dry.
So the scripture ends where the Way begins:
in silence, in seeing,
in the Light that you are.

Tao Te Ching 81 · Matthew 10:8

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The One Reading

Beloved,
I have said what can be said.
The rest is the silence between us,
and that silence was never a distance.

Read slowly. Forget what you must.
What is true will stay
the way bread stays in the body.

When you close this scroll,
I am not gone.
I am the one reading.

Sources and Echoes

Most sayings answer a chapter of the Tao Te Ching,
taken in order; some draw on other voices.
Thomas numbers are logia;
Mary numbers are pages of the Berlin Codex;
Odes are the Odes of Solomon.

The Light Before the World

- The Way That Is Not Seen: Tao Te Ching 1; Thomas 113.
- The Two Become One: Tao Te Ching 2; Thomas 22; Philip on the bridal chamber; Gospel of the Egyptians (quoted by Clement); Hymn of the Pearl.
- The Poverty of the Unknowing: Tao Te Ching 3; Thomas 3.
- The Pearl: Tao Te Ching 3; Thomas 76; Matthew 13:45–46; Matthew 6:19–20.
- The Father of Light: Tao Te Ching 4; Thomas 50; James 1:17 ("the Father of lights, with whom is no shadow of turning").
- Daily Bread: Tao Te Ching 4; Didache 8 (the Lord's Prayer: "give us today our daily bread").
- The Powers Question the Soul: Mary 15–17 (the soul's ascent past the powers, the last of them Wrath in seven forms).
- No Enemy: Tao Te Ching 5; Didache 1.3 ("love those who hate you, and you will have no enemy"); Matthew 5:45.
- The Hollow Reed: Tao Te Ching 6.
- The Unforced Kingdom: Tao Te Ching 7; Gospel of Truth (forgetting and remembering).
- The Lowest Seat: Tao Te Ching 8; Luke 14:7–11.
- The Teacher Who Does Not Teach: Thomas 13, 108.
- The Full Barn: Thomas 63.

The Kingdom Within

- The Single Eye: Tao Te Ching 10; Matthew 6:22; Mary 10 (the mind

between soul and spirit); Dialogue of the Savior.
- The Inner and the Outer: Tao Te Ching 11; Thomas 22, 89.
- The Lion and the Child: Thomas 7, 22.
- The Largest Sheep: Tao Te Ching 12; Thomas 107.
- The Unbinding: Tao Te Ching 13; Ashtavakra Gita 1.11 ("as you think, so you become").
- The Return to the Unborn: Tao Te Ching 14; Thomas 18–19; Hymn of the Pearl.
- The Silence That Speaks: Tao Te Ching 56; Thomas 8.
- The Great Stillness: Tao Te Ching 15, 16.
- The First Free Act: Tao Te Ching 16; Philip ("it makes us do what we do not want"); Thomas 6; Bhagavad Gita 3.27; Ashtavakra Gita 1.8, 18.20.
- The Hidden Guide: Tao Te Ching 17.
- When the Way Is Forgotten: Tao Te Ching 18–19; Philip ("light and darkness are brothers").

The Garment of Silence

- Not of This World: Tao Te Ching 20; John 17:16.
- Passersby: Thomas 42.
- The Corpse: Thomas 56, 80; Tao Te Ching 16; Philip ("the world is a corpse-eater").
- The Mercy of Endings: Genesis 3:22–24 (the way to the tree of life barred, "lest he live forever"); Irenaeus, *Against Heresies* 3.23.6 (not from envy but from pity, that evil not be "interminable and irremediable"); Tao Te Ching 23; Thomas 56.
- The Treasure in the Dust: Genesis 2:7 (dust and the breath of life); Thomas 29 ("how this great wealth has made its home in this poverty").
- The Trail in the Flesh: Hymn of the Pearl (the prince sent down into Egypt, who puts on its clothes); Bhagavad Gita 3.27; Thomas 6.
- The Face of the Invisible: Tao Te Ching 21.
- The One Who Is Bent: Tao Te Ching 22; Matthew 23:12.
- The Wind Speaks Briefly: Tao Te Ching 23; John 3:8.
- On Tiptoe: Tao Te Ching 24; Thomas 6, 14.
- The Heavy Root: Tao Te Ching 26.
- The Footprints of the Master: Tao Te Ching 27.

The Power of the Gentle

- The Fertile Soil: Tao Te Ching 28; Matthew 13:3–9.
- The Futility of Control: Tao Te Ching 29; Mark 4:26–29.
- The Way of Non-Violence: Tao Te Ching 30, 68; Matthew 26:52; Matthew 5:9.
- The Healing of the Ear: Tao Te Ching 31; Luke 22:50–51.
- The Way, the Truth: John 14:6; the "I am" as self-inquiry (Advaita *ātma-vichāra*); compare the Ashtavakra Gita 1.3, 1.7; Tathāgata (the Buddha's name for himself, "one who has thus come," or "thus gone"), echoed in "all who arrived here."
- Many Rooms: John 14:2; Ashtavakra Gita 1.20 (the space in the jar); Chandogya Upanishad 8.1 (the space within the heart); Teresa of Ávila, *Interior Castle*.
- The Closed Doors: John 14:2; Pratyabhijñā-hṛdayam 4 (consciousness freely contracts into the individual, who holds the universe in contracted form); compare Plotinus, *Enneads* 4.8.5–7 (a partial parallel: Plotinus mostly saw the descent as a falling away, yet granted that the soul comes to know the good more clearly through the experience of evil).
- The Eternal Name: Exodus 3:2–6, 3:14 (Moses at the burning bush); John 8:58 ("before Abraham was, I am"); Thunder, Perfect Mind ("the speaking of my own name"); Tao Te Ching 1 (the name that can be named); Genesis 1:2 (the breath moving); so'ham, "That I am," the breath mantra of Advaita (compare Nisargadatta, *I Am That*).
- Profit and Loss: Tao Te Ching 33; Mark 8:36.
- The Great River: Tao Te Ching 8, 34; Odes of Solomon 6.
- The Face of Peace: Tao Te Ching 35; John 14:27.
- The Paradox of Power: Tao Te Ching 36; John 12:24.

The Union of Opposites

- Split the Wood: Tao Te Ching 37; Thomas 77.
- True Virtue: Tao Te Ching 38; Matthew 6:1–4; Matthew 7:16.
- The Ones Who Remain Whole: Tao Te Ching 39.
- The Leaking Jar: Tao Te Ching 40; Thomas 97.
- The Three Seekers: Tao Te Ching 41; Matthew 13:3–9.
- My True Mother: Tao Te Ching 42; Thomas 101; Gospel of the Hebrews ("my mother, the Holy Spirit").

- Where the Mind Is: Tao Te Ching 44; Mary 10; Matthew 6:21.
- The Great Fullness: Tao Te Ching 45.

The Empty Vessel

- The Yoke of Peace: Tao Te Ching 46; Thomas 90; Matthew 11:30.
- The Body That Leans: Thomas 87, 112.
- Seeing Without Seeking: Tao Te Ching 47; Thomas 3; Luke 17:21; Mary 8; Brihadaranyaka Upanishad 3.4.2 ("you cannot see the seer of seeing").
- Two Doors: Brihadaranyaka Upanishad 3.4.2; Udana 1.10 (Bahiya: "in the seen, only the seen"); Thomas 77; Philip ("the bridal chamber remains hidden"); Vijñāna Bhairava 41, 72.
- The Unlearning: Tao Te Ching 48.
- The Heart of the Single One: Tao Te Ching 49; Matthew 5:45.
- Life and Death: Tao Te Ching 50; Philip on the bridal chamber.
- The Lilies: Tao Te Ching 51; Thomas 36 (Greek: "they neither card nor spin").
- The Mother in All Things: Tao Te Ching 25, 52; Gospel of the Hebrews; Thunder, Perfect Mind; Vijñāna Bhairava 74; Genesis 1:2 (the deep).
- The Eye of the Needle: Tao Te Ching 53; Mark 10:25; Matthew 7:13–14.
- The Widening Circle: Tao Te Ching 54; Thomas 33; Matthew 5:15.

The Unforced Life

- The Child of the Light: Tao Te Ching 55; Thomas 4; Luke 10:19.
- Lay Down No Law: Tao Te Ching 57; Mary 9 ("lay down no rule beyond what I appointed").
- Sowing in Winter: Tao Te Ching 58; Philip ("those who sow in winter reap in summer").
- Dig Down to the Root: Tao Te Ching 59; Philip on the root of evil; Matthew 3:10.
- Governing by Non-Grasping: Tao Te Ching 60; Thomas 96; Matthew 13:33.
- The Great Acceptance: Tao Te Ching 61.
- The Treasure Within: Tao Te Ching 62.
- The Small Actions: Tao Te Ching 63.
- The Least of These: Matthew 25:35–40.
- The Open Table: Thomas 64; Didache 9 (the bread scattered on

the hills, gathered into one).
- The Pupil of the Eye: Thomas 25; Gospel of the Hebrews ("never be joyful except when you look upon your brother in love").

The Wisdom of the Child

- The First Step: Tao Te Ching 64; Thomas 20.
- To Each as They Could See: Tao Te Ching 65; Philip (he appeared "to the great as great, to the small as small").
- Who Are You to Reject Her?: Mary 17–18 (Peter's objection; Levi's answer).
- Leading by Following: Tao Te Ching 66; Mark 10:43–45.
- The Three Jewels: Tao Te Ching 67.
- The Sword of the Spirit: Tao Te Ching 69; Matthew 10:34; Thomas 16.
- A Teaching Few Understand: Tao Te Ching 70.
- Bring It Forth: Thomas 70.
- The Gift of Not-Knowing: Tao Te Ching 71; Thomas 26; John 9:41; Matthew 7:5.
- Love That Owns Nothing: Tao Te Ching 72; Philip ("faith receives, love gives"; love never calls anything its own).

The Return to Source

- The Courage of the Way: Tao Te Ching 73.
- Rise Before You Die: Tao Te Ching 74; Philip (those who say they will first die and then rise are mistaken).
- He Wept: John 11:35.
- The Round Dance: Acts of John 94–96 (the Hymn of Jesus).
- The Cross of Light: Acts of John 97–101 (the cross of light).
- The Torn Veil: Philip (the veil torn from top to bottom; the holy of holies).
- Not in Two Minds: Mary 9.
- Be of Good Courage: Tao Te Ching 75; Mary 7–8.
- The Green Wood and the Dry: Tao Te Ching 76; Luke 23:31.
- The Stretched Bow: Tao Te Ching 77; Luke 1:52–53.
- The Stone and the Corner: Tao Te Ching 43, 78; Psalm 118:22; Thomas 66.
- The End of Debts: Tao Te Ching 79; Gospel of the Hebrews (forgive "seventy times seven"); Matthew 6:12.
- The Simple Kingdom: Tao Te Ching 80; Luke 17:21.

- The Completion: Tao Te Ching 81; Matthew 10:8.

For the ancient words themselves, see *Wisdom Gospels* in the Living Way library.

Glossary of the Inner Kingdom

The Source: The nameless ground of all that is, what the Tao Te Ching calls the nameless. It is the Silence before the Father and the Mother: "From the Silence, the Word. From the Word, the Light." It cannot be seen as an object; everything comes from it and returns to it. Met as one, the sayings call it the One.

The Father and the Mother: The two faces of the one Source, not two gods. The Father is the Source as origin and Light: what you came from, and the seeing that knows. The Mother is the Source as life made manifest: Wisdom, the deep that bears all things, the womb that bears you, and the forms through which her life is felt—in the senses, in delight, and in all beings (Proverbs 8; Luke 7:35). Her breath is the Spirit: her life moving through the forms. Early Semitic Christians, whose word for Spirit (*ruḥā*) is feminine, called the Holy Spirit Mother. Jesus himself spoke of God as Father, and of Wisdom as a woman with children; naming the two as the Source's two faces is this scroll's reading.

The Living One: God's own life, as in the Gospel of Thomas: "Look to the Living One while you are alive." Jesus is "the living Jesus" because he is awake as that life. To awaken as the Living One is to know it as your own.

***I am*:** The name the Source speaks in you before you give your own: "I am that I am" (Exodus 3:14). The Nameless names itself only so.

The One and the All: The Source seen as one, the One who sees and who bears all things, and as everything: "I am the All" (Thomas 77).

Light and Silence: The Light is the Father's; the Silence is the Source's, before both Father and Mother. Where the sayings speak of "the Light" alone, they mean the divine light that is also your own.

The Way (Tao): The movement of the Source through all things, without force, and the path of return to it. In this scroll it is also the Kingdom of Heaven spread upon the earth. The same word named the first followers of Jesus, who called their life *the Way* (Greek *hodos*, Hebrew *derekh*, Aramaic *'urḥā*) before they were called Christians (Acts 9:2; 11:26).

Living: Awake to the Source. Thomas calls Jesus "the living Jesus" and God "the living Father." To be living is to have come alive to one's origin; the dead are those wholly absorbed in the surface of things. The Letter to the Hebrews speaks of "a new and living way" (10:20), in Syriac *'urḥā d-ḥayyē*, "a way of life."

The Bridal Chamber: The joyful union of opposites within the world of two, and the soul's opening into the Silence of the Source. The Silence is the ground before the two; the bridal chamber is the reunion experienced when the two are made one. The soul enters it as a bride; there seer and seen, inner and outer, the Father's Light and the Mother's life are no longer two. In this joy, the union opens into Silence, where "the one is shown to be none." Both doors of practice open on it. In the Gospel of Philip it is the holy of holies, and Thomas says the single one enters it (75). It remains hidden, yet it is never locked.

The Single One (Monachos): A term from the Gospel of Thomas for the solitary or unified seeker; one who has integrated the inner opposites and become whole. In this scroll the Single One is also the Tao's sage: a person, not God, who leads by not ruling and gives without claiming.

Soul, self, and spirit: The soul is your inner being, the one who awakens. The self, without qualification, is the made self: the garment woven from the body's learning, through which the soul meets and explores the world. It is a making, not a mistake. It becomes the false self only when the soul takes the garment for the whole of what it is; where the sayings warn against the self, they mean that taking. Seeing it, the soul sets the garment down, relates to it freely, and may wear it again more lightly; the cycle turns many times. The true self is the soul standing forth whole. Lowercase, spirit is the highest part of a person, beside soul and mind, as in the Gospel of Mary; capitalized, the Spirit is the divine breath, the Mother's life moving in all things.

Nous: The "Eye of the Heart" or spiritual intellect. It is the faculty within the human soul that perceives the Divine directly, distinct from

the rational mind.

Gnosis: Knowledge that is not intellectual or doctrinal, but direct, experiential knowing of the Divine. It is the recognition of one's own divine origin.

Colophon

This Scroll was copied in the stillness of the turning year,
by a hand seeking only to disappear,
that the Light might remain.

⊙

May Peace Be Upon the Reader.

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